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NAMFREL: BARMM Parliamentary Elections Show Strong Technical Readiness, but Five Compounding Risks Could Fuel a Post-Election Legitimacy Dispute

Mandaluyong City — The National Citizens' Movement for Free Elections (NAMFREL) released its Pre-Election Assessment of the September 14, 2026 Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM) Parliamentary Elections, finding that while the Commission on Elections (COMELEC) is technically and logistically prepared to administer the region's first regular parliamentary polls, five compounding risk factors could generate disputes over the outcome's legitimacy regardless of who wins.

Strong Technical Readiness

NAMFREL's assessment confirms that COMELEC's automated election system, ballot printing and deployment, legal and regulatory calendar, voter education efforts, and audit mechanisms are all rated "Ready." More than 2.3 million ballots have been printed for 2.39 million registered voters, and the Random Manual Audit Memorandum of Agreement — jointly signed with PPCRV, NAMFREL, the Philippine Statistics Authority, and DepEd — was formalized on August 28.

"COMELEC has done its part on the mechanics of this election," said Angel S. Averia Jr., NAMFREL National Chairperson. "The harder problem is not whether the machines will work. It is whether the political environment surrounding this election will allow its result to be accepted as legitimate by all sides."

Five Compounding Fault Lines

NAMFREL's monitoring identifies five risk areas sitting beneath that technical readiness:

- **An unresolved MILF succession fight** between Ahod "Al Haj Murad" Ebrahim and Abdulraof "Sammy Gambar" Macacua, now bleeding into unattributed political violence, including the still-unexplained August 15 ambush of Macacua's convoy.
- **A widening credibility gap** between official "generally peaceful" messaging and independent conflict-monitoring data. COMELEC



and the Philippine National Police recorded just one validated election-related incident between July 16 and September 4, while the independent Climate Conflict Action Asia (CCAA) tracker recorded 611 incidents and 235 deaths across Mindanao in the same broader period — a divergence pattern NAMFREL notes recurred in both the 2023 and 2025 election cycles.

- **Unresolved corruption findings**, including a ₱2.2 billion Commission on Audit-flagged procurement fraud finding at the Ministry of Basic, Higher and Technical Education, now being actively weaponized in campaign messaging between rival camps.
- **A structurally under-scrutinized private-armed-group and normalization deficit**, with no confirmed, cycle-specific count of private armed groups available in open reporting despite the peace process's normalization track remaining, in the words of the independent Third Party Monitoring Team, “in initial stages” twelve years after the Comprehensive Agreement on the Bangsamoro was signed.
- **Credible, repeated, unresolved allegations** — made by both major camps, in mirror-image fashion, in 2024 and again this cycle — that Malacañang's own political vehicle has been favoring one side in the region's internal rivalry. NAMFREL rates this the single highest risk in its consolidated register, scoring it Critical and Almost Certain to shape post-election narratives.

“None of these five fault lines, on its own, points to a failure of this election,” Averia said. “Together, they create multiple plausible paths to a legitimacy dispute after the votes are counted — because the very institutions asked to certify this election as credible are the same ones whose account is most contested by independent monitors and by whichever side loses.”

Infrastructure as an Integrity Issue

The assessment also flags the Mindanao power grid's thin reserve margins heading into E-Day week — at points below 100 MW against a historic safe-operating threshold of 800 MW — as a direct election-integrity concern rather than a purely logistical one, since a power outage during the September 14 evening counting and transmission window could produce delays that are, to the public, indistinguishable from tampering or



dispute. NAMFREL is calling on COMELEC, the Department of Energy, and the National Grid Corporation of the Philippines to communicate transparently and in real time about the cause of any power transmission delay.

Recommendations

NAMFREL is issuing specific recommendations to COMELEC and its security partners, candidates and political parties, local and international observer organizations, the media, the BARMM electorate, and the business community — including publishing the Random Manual Audit's sampling methodology before E-Day, publicly reconciling official and independent incident counts, and securing public commitments from all major candidates to abide by the parliamentary Chief Minister selection process regardless of seat outcomes.

The full assessment report is available at <https://bit.ly/4gRaMoK>.

Working with the Independent Election Monitoring Center (IEMC)-BARMM, NAMFREL will deploy its citizen-monitoring network throughout BARMM for the September 14 elections and will issue further updates as findings develop.

About NAMFREL

The National Citizens' Movement for Free Elections (NAMFREL) is an accredited, independent, non-partisan citizen election-monitoring organization.

About IEMC-BARMM

IEMC-BARMM is a collaborative effort uniting organizations with deep roots in governance and democratic process work across the region: the Institute for Autonomy and Governance (IAG), the National Citizens' Movement for Free Elections (NAMFREL), Notre Dame University (NDU), the Notre Dame Broadcasting Corporation (NDBC), the Parish Pastoral Council for Responsible Voting (PPCRV) Cotabato City, Climate and Conflict Action Asia (CCAA), the Coalition for Social Accountability and Transparency (CSAT), and Notre Dame of Midsayap College (NDMC).

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